Knightfall & Daybreak

Savant-Guarde

Chapter Seven

• 1.7.1 • 1.7.2 •

Exfiltration

01

KATIYA

If he wasn't handsome, I would have slit his throat. My mind can't catch up fast enough for all the semantics, but I know exactly what he means.

I can feel it.

My face flushes. "You degenerate! You lecherous, filthy animal, breaking into my house to . . . to—"

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"I swear, I didn't break in here," he insists. His face is redder than mine. He covers his crotch with his hands, as if hiding the pitched tent can make me forget. "The door was open. I just walked in."

"The door was locked, you fool," I say, pointing to the narrowly-cracked entry door behind me, but he gestures with his head to the small closet. "The closet? How would you break in through a damn closet? There's no windows in there."

"I know, but please. I'm as confused as you are," he says. "Give me a chance to explain."

"You're excited, not confused!" I point the dagger between his legs. "You don't have the right to be confused right now. I'm the one that's confused at how—"

"—Would you let me explain? Dear God!"

"It's Gods, you heretic," I tell him. "Respect other races. We're not the only one that shares Fosroth, and all our Gods have proven their presence."

"God, I said," he says. "A real god, not the ones you cosplay freaks pretend to worship."

"Do you want to be executed for apostasy? Because I can do that for you, right now," I notice that his eyes keep falling on the closet. The closet, my bare legs, my breastplate, and then the closet. I circle between him and the door, leaving only the entrance as an escape: like coaxing a rat out of the house without having to kill it.

"What I want is to go home," he says. "Not to get stabbed by a letter opener. I'm your neighbor, and the door between our units was open. I was simply trying to tell you," the liar insists. He heaves for a couple breaths. "Did you really have to tackle me to get your point across?"

"You do not live here. This is the Military District. Besides — you've proved that you are far too weak to live here," I say, approaching him with the dagger.

"You bitch, I can bench a plate at least," he says.

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"Putting plates on benches? What, are you a fat oaf that eats outside all day?" but he looks reasonably fit beneath his ruined shirt. Defined shoulder muscles, trained without Essence . . . maybe he's a laboring refugee from the North?

He raises his hands as he tries to stand up with only his legs, but he can't. "I'm sorry to intrude. Look. I know you might be into cosplay or whatever, but this is taking things way too far."

"Cosplay?"

"Costume play. At first I thought it was old people living here: the kettle, the candles . . . I mean, the whole damn house is set up like Skyrim."

Costume?

A fucking costume?

"This is not a COSTUME!"

He shrinks at the thunder in my voice. His singed nobleman's shirt hangs open as he edges towards the front door on his hands and knees, and I follow him step-for-step.

"Do you know how hard I worked for this?"

"Yeah . . . lots of trips to the craft store," he adds.

"How hard I worked to wear this proudly as a guardian?"

"Yeah. Did you make it during the craft foam sale? I go there for the graphing pencils."

"What the Res are you talking about?"

"Mechanical pencils," he rambles. "Point-five is a toothpick, and point-nine is like a fucking crayon—"

"You dare to insult me like this? For what, because I'm a female guard?"

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"No. Of course not, you're very convincing." His voice crackles on every other syllable, trying to inject some abject form of flattery. "It's amazing. Prop knife? Form-fit foam from the craft store, spray-painted to look like metal armor? Even the stitching looks like an eighteenth-century corset. I can tell you've put a lot of time into it. You're a lot like my older cousin, and I'm sure you have loads of followers like she does. I know I'd follow you."

"You're too yellow to follow me anywhere," I say.

"On-line, I mean," he says.

"On what line?" I ask. "The front? You would never get close. They'd keep you busy peeling potatoes with such soft hands."

"Soft hands? Please. You're the job that banks on soft hands. While you're busy pleasuring perverts over your webcam, I work in an office. Designing the damn future. Because the rest of us have to work real jobs, not getting paid by thirsty horndogs that jerk off to Shakespeare."

"The real work is defending the ungrateful, undeserving gentry like you. Why don't you crawl back to mummy and daddy dearest for another bump to your filthy allowance?"

That last line would provoke any true noble. I expect him to go cry fowl to his underpaid servants, to his nanny, or to his absentee parents, complaining all way up the chain to my captain. I sincerely hope he does, because Aldrin is backwater enough to hate anything that wears its wealth and wreaks of privilege.

But hes's not that kind of upset. He doesn't seem offended in any way. This idiot still holds a sense of humor, as if he thinks it's all a ruse. The further the corners of his mouth crease on a laugh, the more it infuriates me, and as he stands, he opens his stupid mouth to cross the line.

"Enough pretend. Your knife isn't even real."

"Pray tell, does this feel real?"

I take a slash at his arm, trying to carve him with something small and impermanent: small enough to disappear in a day, but enough to remember the lesson. But the fool flinches, blocking my dagger with his

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left hand.

Idiot.

The edge catches on his palm, drawing an instant, deep line of gushing blood. His expression changes in an instant, as if surprised that knives have an edge to them. Maybe I'll have to explain next that my Essenced fire actually burns, and water actually drowns.

"You . . . you actually . . ." he starts, his back pressed against the front door as he watches the blood trickle down his left wrist, absorbing in the tarnished fabric of his charred left sleeve.

I flick the crimson from the dagger, flipping it around to imply the next strike will impale him. "It's time for you to leave. It's getting late, and by the Gods, I'd rather abstain from filing a casualty report tonight."

He fumbles for the door with his working hand, wrapping his left palm in more of the pristine, white fabric, struggling to grasp the handle when his eyes are on the weapon. "Jesus Christ! Are you insane? Do you have no boundary with your stupid fantasy? Castle Law or not, I'm calling the police."

"Get out," I say.

"You're going down for this," he says.

"I said, GET OUT!"

As soon as the door cracks enough to silhouette his body against the night, I lift my leg and boot him square in the chest, planting a muddy print on the last untarnished space in the fabric. He falls over the first set of steps and lands in the dirt, groaning as I slam the door shut.

He'll live.

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02

KATIYA

I rush to the window, throwing the shades open just enough to peer into the darkness, drawn by my biting curiosity to see what unfolds. What an idiot — now he's struggling to tear the sleeve off his bloodstained shirt, ripping at the fabric where my Essenced plume singed it black.

But it still bothers me. Why was he so drawn to the shallow closet? Even under duress, I don't know how he could be stupid enough to insist he entered through a door. There's surely nothing in this column of a cottage worth breaking into — especially into the home of a Royal Knight — unless he's some devious cretin that is after my intimates.

After I back away from the window and toss the bloody dagger in the sink, I approach the closet door.

Or at least I thought it was a closet.

The space beyond the door frame spans for less than a foot before the faint candlelight is swallowed by darkness. But the darkness is so dense and miasmic, like peering through murky water.

The tunnel opens itself to me as I approach the door. From the lines implied by the floors and walls, the small cupboard should be no deeper than a couple feet (enough to store winter uniforms and snowshoes for the cold season), but I find no definite end. The edge where the splintered floor meets the jagged wall just fades into obscurity, all the way though to the unit on the other side, where an unfamiliar twinkle of multicolored lights pierce the smooth walls.

The corridor might be short, but it's still just a little too long. The neighboring wall would have to be deeper than the walls around Fort Gaffesend!

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It must be a trick of his. He could be a cross-blood like Pax, except Auvryan; able to mess with minds; skilled enough in his race's gift to conjure convincing illusions with his Essence. Maybe that's why he seemed so powerless with his Human gifts. Maybe he conjured that splitting headache before I barged in, or maybe he speaks through thoughts, unaccustomed to verbal speech, speaking words of a foreign language though my mind heard something else. Is my mind being twisted further, to show something that isn't there? Does he still deceive me from beyond the door? I refuse to fall for this pathetic excuse of a trick, so I decide to test the bewildering portal.

I reach first with my gauntlet, dragging through the viscous black as if collapsing spiderwebs. I notice the breeze at my back, strong enough to pierce the layers of my uniform, ushering me deeper and deeper. My trembling hand passes where the wall should be, and then my arm, and then the rest of my body, and as all the sound of the quaint cottage and the outside world fade behind me, I realize I'm twice as deep as the rules of space should allow. I think of the old stories of the Verdalans, the masters of space whose bodies descended from the fibrous jungle, defending their ancient capital with an infinite wall of twisting jungle. Just as their Essence warped space, entrapping their adversaries in endless loops of attrition, I feel my stomach twist as my senses confirm a truth that the mind refuses to accept.

The room is dark, and though I can't make out the meager spread of items, I can sense how strange the shapes in this room are: so smooth and straight, as if they were cut by divine hands. When I find a glint in the artifacts on the shelves and walls—even the shelves themselves—I marvel at how much metal must have been wasted to produce all these things. He must be rich if he can waste money like this: maybe he's so rich that he bribed the Guard to let him live here, in a prime spot looking across the water.

Does he actually live next door? Did I really mistake this as a closet? My metal boots clatter like hooves against the reflective wood floor, and I trace my finger along the polished granite table, trying to imagine how the resources got here.

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A crunch startles me. On the floor are what looks like hand-painted ration cans, but they're all crushed and ruined.

I'm startled again when I hear snoring in the corner, and I find another odd stranger. A friend? A lover? Maybe a visitor past curfew? My feet sink into the carpet when I approach him, wondering again how the scruffy noble could ever afford such luxurious flooring.

The entire room stinks of man, but this one smells especially bad. He mumbles in a drunken stupor before he awakes, blinking his eyes like a toad.

"Uh . . . hey."

"Hello," I say, wishing I had not ditched the dagger.

He asks, "And you are?"

"Katiya. Katiya Breakey-Hilde," I say.

"My homie's got no chill if he's bringing girls like you over while I'm here. Must be desperate since he's got no hoes."

"A hose? Why would you—" I begin to ask, but he cuts me off.

"I think he's upstairs," he tells me, squinting his eyes, and then some semblance of recognition crosses his face. "Wait a minute — you must be from that fantasy escort service down in Denver, what was it called, uh . . . Call To Adventure, or something like that?"

"I only do escort missions through the Royal Guard," I say.

"Hah. Good one," he says.

"It is good," I say.

"Good." He clicks his tongue. "Figures. My boy Cody could never score a baddie like you."

"Cody," I say.

"Yep."

An odd name.

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"And I'm Miguel."

Another odd name.

He says, "But he's a real one, let me tell you. My friend is the best dude you'll ever meet. I love that guy. You might be here for just a night — and, look, I know the whole thing about falling in love with a call girl — but give him a chance, huh? Even if it's just a booty call thing," he says.

His hand grazes the table, accidentally casting some black, slender object on the floor. It bounces twice before colliding with something else. I hear a click, and then behind me, a flash of colorful light envelops the room. I gasp when I turn to look, and my heart jumps into my throat.

Behind the bright window, a mother and daughter are screaming at each other. It gives me such a start that I collapse into the couch. The woman is screaming, the daughter is screaming, I'm screaming, and the man is shouting, trying to free himself from my armor.

I spew a string of apologies as the woman in the window says something about wanting her body back, just as all I want is to go home. Too panicked to realize that the best direction is from whence I came, I sprint for the door as the other guy curses, grasping his leg.

I'll just go around like Cody. We'll trade places.

Just like my intruder, I trip backwards out the door, scraping the edges of the cement with my plate armor as I slide down the sculpted stairs, coming directly to a stop beneath a blinding torchlight. I scramble to my feet to try and run, but everything is so bright and unfamiliar that I fall to my knees.

The sky is cloudless, but I can't find a single star. Lake Garrison is nowhere to be found; instead of the distant lights of my hometown of Hillfar, a pattern of white-and-red dotted lights slide past each other on a hill, somewhere far beyond the eaves of two houses on the other side of the road.

Something loud is approaching. I try to curl into a ball to protect myself, but the armor stiffens me too much. A massive automobile tears past, lighting the entire street with headlamps lodged in the front, unlike

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anything I've ever seen. It sounds like they have an entire orchestra in there behind the glass, but the deafening music fades . . . only to be replaced by two more loud metal chariots that shake the ground.

I'm quivering as I lay there in the grass, wondering where the garden is; why the lake isn't directly across from me; why stars shifted in the sky so swiftly.

An old woman walks on the side of the street, and I consider she's a lamplighter until I see her holding a leash. She notices me crumpled in the grass on the verge of tears.

"Are you alright, sweetheart?" She asks.

"No," I cry.

Her familiar crosses the grass, nuzzling me with its wet nose before it licks my face.

"Oh, that's Doby. She's real friendly with all the young'uns living around here — do you mind dogs? Or are you more of a cat person?"

"I'm a human person. A living human—"

"—I swear to the good Lord in heaven: if this neighborhood is turning into one of those 'college' towns the Facebook talks about, with all these young'uns in their new houses playing trapping music, I'm going to lose it!"

I haven't the time to protest when I hear a hissing noise, and it sounds like the elder is conjuring a serpent. Before I can react, I feel a cloudless rain, followed by a direct blast of water to my face, saturating the clothes beneath my armor in seconds.

"Why? Why do you torment me?" I plead, my tears now inseparable from the water soaking me down to my underwear.

"I didn't set the timer on those sprinklers," she says, and then adds, "damn beatnik."

As I kneel in the muddy grass, sullying my new pants, I watch as the cantankerous woman retreats, dragging the mutt alongside her. A single, white moon hangs in the sky. Blinking red and white flashes somewhere

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even higher, casting smoke in a faint line, leaving the sound of a crackle as it slices the sky. I never knew the sky could be torn.

With my mind petrified, locking my muscles, resigning me to soak in the jets of water, my body decides for me, urging me back inside to pass Cody's cursing companion.

All I want is to return to the comfort of Fosroth where the world is uncomplicated. I want a cup of tea and a book beside the fire as I warm my bones. I will never bear witness to this horrifying illusion again.

I ignore his companion's threat to take shots, though he holds a bottle instead of a gun, — asking if his friend paid for any more guards to defend this house. But as I stumble towards the closet, squeaking my saturated boots with each step, all I find is another figure, standing there at the back of the closet.

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